THE DEFEAT OF THE SPANISH ARMADA

On May 28, 1588, Spanish king Philip II's "Invincible Armada" sailed from Lisbon on the "Enterprise of England." Goaded by English privateers' attacks on his colonial possessions and treasure fleets, and by Queen Elizabeth's support for Dutch rebels in the Netherlands, Philip had decided that England must be taught a lesson. The Armada was to sail through the English Channel and escort a Spanish army from the Netherlands across the North Sea to land in Kent. The original leader of the enterprise was the Marqués de Santa Cruz, Spain's most distinguished admiral, but on his untimely death in February 1588 command had been most reluctantly assumed by the Duke of Medina Sidonia—who, by his own account, "did not understand it and knew nothing about it."

The assembly, equipping, and supply of this vast fleet had been a long and arduous task, rendered more difficult by English raids on Spanish ports. It took the Armada a further three weeks to reach Coruña in northern Spain, and it did not weigh anchor again until July 21. The English were not inclined to wait for the slow-moving Spanish to arrive. The fiery Francis Drake persuaded his commander-in-chief, Lord Howard of Effingham, to attempt the destruction of the Armada before it sailed, but three times ships sent south toward Spain were driven back by bad weather. The English commanders then resolved to base their main force in Plymouth, ready to tackle the Armada as soon as it approached the Channel.

THE COUNTRY ALERTED

The Spanish were spotted off the Lizard on July 29, news conveyed by the lighting of a string of beacons along the coast from Devon to the Scottish border. The Armada was an awesome sight—some 130 ships carrying possibly 18,000 soldiers as well as their complement of sailors. But it was a heterogeneous collection of vessels. Less than 50 of them could be described as fighting ships, the rest being transports. The fleet's Spanish and Portuguese galleons were state-of-the-art warships, although they were slower and less maneuverable than their English equivalents. The English had about 65 galleons and armed merchantmen at Plymouth, with another contingent waiting at the eastern end of the Channel.



Armada medal
This silver medal was made for Dutch prince Maurice of Nassau. The inscription reads "He (Jehovah) blew and they were scattered."

On the day the alarm was raised Howard and Drake were pinned in Plymouth Sound by the wind, but the following morning the wind turned off shore. For most of the next eight days, while they shadowed the Spanish along the Channel, the English held the weather gage. The Armada advanced in a well-disciplined crescent, the fighting ships sheltering the transports in the center. The nimble English ships buzzed tirelessly around the Spanish flanks, harassing them with largely ineffective long-range cannon fire. Whereas the English saw their galleons as gun platforms, the Spanish regarded cannon as ancillary weapons, useful for softening an enemy prior to boarding. Keeping the advantage of the wind, however, the English had no intention of letting the enemy get close enough to board.

By the time the Armada anchored off Calais on August 6, Howard was thoroughly satisfied with his fleet's performance. "We have so daily pursued them at heels," he wrote, "that they never had leisure to stop at any place along our English coast."

